MAGNA-Q PATHWAY SERIES

US Clinical Electives: Scheduling and Visas

How to arrange a clinical elective in the United States, and the immigration categories that govern it

Last verified: 27 August 2026 against aamc.org, students-residents.aamc.org, travel.state.gov, j1visa.state.gov, the eCFR, and the published visiting-student pages of several US medical schools.
Series: Magna-Q free study-craft guides for international medical graduates
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> **Who this is for:** international medical students and graduates trying to arrange clinical experience in the United States. It covers both halves of the problem — getting the placement, and getting into the country legally to do it.
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Read this first. The visa section describes published rules and processes. It does not tell you what you personally qualify for, and it cannot. Immigration categories turn on individual facts, the rules change, and consular officers exercise discretion. Use this to understand the landscape, then confirm everything with the official sources linked at the end and, where the stakes justify it, with a qualified immigration lawyer.

The short version

- Most US electives are now scheduled through one platform: **VSLO**, run by the AAMC.
- The single biggest gate for international applicants is whether **your medical school is a VSLO participating institution**. If it is not, most doors are closed, and they are closing further.
- **A pathway that let students from non-participating schools apply directly is ending.** Yale School of Medicine's published notice states the AAMC VSLO "Free Mover" pathway concludes in **August 2026**, after which VSLO is the only application route for international visiting students there, and students whose institutions do not participate cannot be accepted.
- On the visa side, the decisive question is not which country you are from. It is **whether you are still a medical student or have already graduated.** That one fact determines whether hands-on clinical work is available to you at all.
- Everything here takes longer than you expect. Applications open months ahead, host deadlines are strict, and visa appointment waits in many countries are measured in months.

The three routes, honestly compared

Route one: VSLO. The AAMC's Visiting Student Learning Opportunities programme is the centralised platform US teaching hospitals use to receive visiting-student applications. It connects a network of more than 300 medical schools and teaching hospitals in the US and internationally. This is the main road, and increasingly the only one.

Route two: applying directly to a host institution. This used to be common and is becoming rare. Many schools now state plainly that they do not accept direct applications — Yale's page says it does not accept direct, independent or unsolicited applications, and instructs applicants not to contact departments or faculty to ask about placements. Weill Cornell goes further and states that students who contact clinical departments directly will be **disqualified** from participating.

That is worth pausing on. The instinct when you want something badly is to email a professor and make your case. In this particular system, that instinct will cost you the placement.

Route three: paid placement providers. Companies that arrange observerships and rotations for a fee. Some are legitimate; quality and cost vary enormously, and a placement arranged this way is not the same thing as a rotation at a teaching hospital with a letter from a faculty supervisor. If you go this way, ask exactly which institution, exactly which supervisor, whether the experience is hands-on or observation only, and whether a letter of recommendation is realistically obtainable. Get the answers in writing before you pay.

How VSLO actually works

There are two roles. A **Home institution** sends its students out. A **Host institution** receives them. Institutions outside the United States can participate in the Global Network.

Your medical school must be a participating Home institution for you to apply through the system. This is the gate, and it is the thing to check before you spend any time on anything else. The AAMC publishes a searchable list of participating institutions.

If your school is not on it, your realistic options are: ask your dean's office to join — the process starts with an interest form submitted to the AAMC — or look at hosts that still accept applications outside the platform, a shrinking group.

The steps

1. **Confirm your school participates.** Check the AAMC's published list before anything else.
2. **Create your account** through the VSLO application service. If you have used other AAMC services before, the same account works.
3. **Complete your profile.** It becomes part of every application you submit, so accuracy matters more than speed here.
4. **Search the catalogue.** You can filter by specialty, institution, location, language and estimated expenses. Only opportunities you are actually eligible for will be visible to you, which saves a great deal of time.
5. **Check each host's own page** inside the system for their specific requirements, dates and fees. These vary wildly and the host's rules override any general advice.

6. **Your home school releases your application.** Home institutions review and release student applications and track progress, so your dean's office is part of the chain whether you like it or not. Build in time for them.
7. **Submit, then wait.** Many hosts review only after a deadline rather than on a rolling basis.

Timing: work backwards, and start earlier than feels sensible

Catalogues open early in the year for the following academic year. Two published examples from the current cycle give you the shape of it: UCLA's catalogue opened for viewing on 26 January 2026 with applications opening 9 March 2026; Harvard Medical School's applications for July 2026 to June 2027 rotations opened on VSLO with rotations for international students available October to March only.

That last detail matters and catches people repeatedly. **Several hosts restrict international students to particular months.** Harvard's international window is October to March. If your plan was a June elective, it may not exist at that institution regardless of how strong your application is.

Deadlines are firm and often earlier than you would guess:

- Weill Cornell requires applications **at least 60 days before the start date**, and post-acceptance documents at least **30 days** before.
- Cornell also limits its international programme to **final-year students** and requires applications no more than six months ahead of the earliest chosen elective.

Note the squeeze that creates: not more than six months ahead, not less than sixty days ahead, final year only, in whichever months they allow international students. Your actual window can be a few weeks wide. Find it before you plan around it.

What you will be asked for

Requirements differ by host, but the recurring list is short enough to prepare in advance:

- **Official medical school transcript**, usually uploaded by your home school rather than by you
- **AAMC Standard Immunization Form**, completed and signed
- **Tuberculosis clearance**, often required within a year of the rotation dates
- **Professional liability (malpractice) insurance** — a commonly stated minimum is $1 million per occurrence and $3 million aggregate
- **CV**

- **Statement of intent** — often very short. UCLA asks for 150 words or fewer on why you want that department
- **Letter of recommendation** from a clinical faculty member
- **Proof of good academic standing** and completion of core clerkships
- **English language documentation**, at some hosts
- **Fees** — VSLO-associated fees plus whatever the host charges

Two practical notes. First, **the immunisation form is the most common cause of delay**, because it needs a physician's signature, sometimes titres, and occasionally vaccines you have to actually go and get. Start it the month you decide to apply, not the month you apply. Second, **liability insurance may not be straightforward to obtain in your country** at the coverage levels US hospitals require. Check early whether your school provides it or whether you need to buy it separately.

What the elective is actually worth

Be clear-eyed about what you are buying, because the cost is significant and the value varies.

Hands-on rotations produce the letters that matter. A US faculty member who supervised you doing the work can write that they watched you take a history, present a patient and function on a team. That is a fundamentally different document from a letter saying you attended.

Observerships are worth less, but not nothing. For graduates in particular they may be the only thing available, and they still provide system familiarity and a relationship with a US physician.

System familiarity is real value. Most IMGs who struggle in their first residency weeks struggle with documentation, the electronic record, how rounds run and how a patient is presented — not with medicine. An elective is where you learn that.

Not every institution accepts international students at all. Louisiana State University's visiting student page states it does not accept international students for visiting rotations. The University of Oklahoma states the same. Check before you build hopes around a name.

Everything in this section is descriptive. It sets out categories and requirements as published by the US government. It is not advice about your situation, and no article can be. Visa issuance is never guaranteed.

The question that determines everything

Before you look at any visa category, answer this: **are you currently enrolled in medical school, or have you graduated?**

The published rules treat those two situations very differently, and the difference is not cosmetic.

For students still enrolled: the B-1 medical clerkship provision

The US Department of State's **Foreign Affairs Manual** recognises use of the B-1 category for a person studying at a foreign medical school who seeks to enter the United States temporarily to take an **elective clerkship at a US medical school's hospital, without remuneration from the hospital**.

The important limits, as published:

- **It applies to medical students, not to physicians who have already completed medical school.**
- **The clerkship must be unpaid.** No salary, no stipend, no compensation of any kind.
- It contemplates students in the normal third or fourth year of their programme.
- The B category permits a limited stay, and a rotation running beyond six months does not fit comfortably within it.

The practical consequence is that an enrolled medical student may undertake a genuine hands-on clerkship under this provision. That is the route most international students on US electives use.

For graduates: observation, not participation

If you have already graduated, the clerkship provision above does not apply to you.

There is a separate published basis under which a medical doctor may enter as a B-1 visitor **to observe US medical practice and consult with colleagues on techniques, provided there is no remuneration** from a US source. That is an observership. It is observation, not hands-on clinical work.

This is the single most misunderstood point in this entire area, and getting it wrong has consequences at the border and potentially for future applications. A graduate who arranges what is described as a "hands-on rotation" and enters as a visitor is in a position they should understand clearly before they board the plane. If a provider is selling a graduate a hands-on placement, ask them directly, in writing, what immigration category they believe it falls under.

The Visa Waiver Program

Nationals of participating countries travelling for fewer than 90 days may be able to use the **Visa Waiver Program** with prior authorisation through **ESTA**, entering in WB status, which functions as the B-1 equivalent for permitted business purposes. Columbia's visiting student page describes exactly this route for eligible students.

Most African countries are not in the Visa Waiver Program. Check the current designated-country list rather than assuming either way.

The J-1 student intern category

A separate route exists under the Exchange Visitor Program. The **student intern** category, defined in federal regulation, is for a student enrolled in a degree programme at a post-secondary institution **outside** the United States coming temporarily for a structured internship that reinforces their academic study.

Published features:

- Requires a **designated programme sponsor**, which issues **Form DS-2019**. You cannot self-sponsor.
- Requires **Form DS-7002**, the Training/Internship Placement Plan, signed by you and your supervisor before the DS-2019 is issued.
- The sponsor must **verify your English language ability**.
- Minimum duration around **three weeks**; maximum **twelve months per degree level**, which may be split into shorter periods.
- **You must return to your home institution** to complete your degree afterwards.
- **Participation after completing your degree is not permitted.**
- Requires proof of sufficient funds and specified insurance coverage.

In practice this route depends entirely on the US institution being willing to sponsor you, and many will not for a short elective because the administrative burden is substantial. Where a host offers it, take it seriously — it is a cleaner status for a longer or more structured placement.

What you will need at the consulate and the border

Whichever route applies, the documents that consistently matter:

- **Form DS-160** for a B visa application, plus the appointment and fee
- **The host institution's pre-approval or invitation letter**, stating the exact dates and the nature of the activity. Columbia instructs students to bring this to the consulate *and* to present it again to the officer at the port of entry

- **Proof of enrolment** and good standing from your medical school
- **Evidence of funds** to cover the entire stay
- **Evidence of ties to your home country** and of intent to return
- For J-1: **DS-2019 and DS-7002** together

At the port of entry, the officer decides your admission and the status annotated on your I-94. Being sent to secondary inspection is not unusual and is not by itself a problem — being unable to explain clearly and consistently what you are doing, for how long, unpaid, and when you are leaving, is. Know your own answers before you are asked.

Timing, realistically

Visa appointment waits vary enormously between posts and change constantly. In several countries the wait for a visitor visa appointment has run to many months. The Department of State publishes current appointment wait times by location — check yours before you commit to elective dates, not after.

Work backwards: elective start date → post-acceptance documents due (often 30 days prior) → visa appointment → appointment wait at your post → DS-160 and fee. For many applicants this means beginning the visa process **before** they have finished celebrating the acceptance.

Mistakes we see repeatedly

- **Emailing departments directly.** At several institutions this disqualifies you outright.
- **Assuming your school participates in VSLO.** Check the published list first. Everything else depends on it.
- **Missing the international-only month windows.** Several hosts restrict international students to specific months.
- **Leaving the immunisation form until last.** It is the most common cause of a missed deadline.
- **A graduate booking a "hands-on rotation" without understanding the category it falls under.**
- **Booking flights before the visa is issued.** Issuance is never guaranteed and consular processing can take longer than anticipated.
- **Not checking whether the host accepts international students at all.** Some state plainly that they do not.
- **Underestimating total cost.** Host fees, VSLO fees, insurance, flights, accommodation, visa fees. Add it up before applying, not after being accepted.

Official sources

What	Where
VSLO programme overview and student resources	students-residents.aamc.org — Visiting Student Learning Opportunities
VSLO participating institution lists	aamc.org — VSLO for institutions
Joining VSLO (for your school's dean's office)	aamc.org — Join the VSLO Program
US visitor visa information and DS-160	travel.state.gov
Visa appointment wait times by post	travel.state.gov
Visa Waiver Program and ESTA	travel.state.gov · esta.cbp.dhs.gov
Exchange Visitor Program, J-1 categories, DS-2019 and DS-7002	j1visa.state.gov · travel.state.gov
Exchange Visitor Program regulations, including the student intern category	eCFR, Title 22 Part 62
Individual host requirements, dates and fees	The host institution's own visiting-student pages

Source log

Claim	Source
VSLO connects a network of more than 300 medical schools and teaching hospitals; Home and Host roles; institutions outside the US participate in the Global Network	aamc.org, Join the VSLO Program; Our VSLO Networks
Only opportunities you are eligible for are visible in the catalogue; search by institution, location, expenses, language, specialty	AAMC VSLO Student Essentials
Home institutions review and release applications and determine elective credit	aamc.org, Join the VSLO Program
Free Mover pathway concludes August 2026; VSLO thereafter the only route; non-participating institutions cannot be accepted; no direct or unsolicited applications	Yale School of Medicine, Visiting International Student Elective Program
Direct contact with departments results in disqualification	Weill Cornell Medicine, Visiting International Students
60-day application and 30-day post-acceptance deadlines; final-year only; apply no more than six months ahead	Weill Cornell Medicine visiting student pages
International students may apply for rotations October–March only	Harvard Medical School Visiting Students Program
2026–27 catalogue viewing 26 January, applications 9 March; 150-word statement of intent; TB clearance within a year; liability insurance requirement	David Geffen School of Medicine at UCLA, VSLO pages
$1M/$3M liability insurance minimum; some institutions do not accept international students	LSU Health New Orleans School of Medicine visiting student page
Institution does not accept visiting students from international institutions	University of Oklahoma College of Medicine
B-1 provision for foreign medical students taking an unpaid elective clerkship; does not extend to those who have completed medical school	US Department of State Foreign Affairs Manual, 9 FAM 402.2-5
B-1 basis for a medical doctor observing US medical practice without remuneration	US Department of State Foreign Affairs Manual
Visa Waiver Program / WB status route for eligible students	Columbia University Vagelos College of Physicians and Surgeons, visiting students guidance
J-1 student intern: DS-2019 and DS-7002, sponsor designation, English verification, 3-week minimum, 12-month maximum per degree level, return requirement, no participation after degree completion	22 CFR Part 62; j1visa.state.gov; university sponsor documentation

Flags — verify these before acting

1. **The Free Mover change is sourced to Yale's own published notice.** It is a host institution describing an AAMC pathway. Confirm the position directly with the AAMC and with each host you are targeting, since implementation may differ between institutions.
2. **Foreign Affairs Manual provisions are summarised here in plain English.** The FAM is guidance to consular officers, not a promise to applicants. Read the current text yourself, and note it is revised without announcement.
3. **All host dates, deadlines, fees and eligibility rules change annually.** Every institution-specific figure in this guide is an illustration of the pattern, not a commitment by that institution. Check the current cycle.
4. **Visa appointment wait times change constantly.** Check the Department of State's current figures for your post.
5. **Visa Waiver Program designated countries change.** Check the current list.
6. **This guide does not cover paid clinical work, residency, or any category permitting employment.** Those are different regimes entirely.
7. Re-verify this guide by **1 December 2026**, and sooner for anything relating to the VSLO pathway change.

Nothing in this guide is legal or immigration advice. Every process described can be completed directly with the AAMC, the host institution and the US Department of State at the published fees. Where your circumstances are unusual — a gap since graduation, a prior visa refusal, a complicated academic record — that is precisely the situation in which a qualified immigration lawyer is worth the money.